HOW MUCH HUMAN WORK IS BEHIND AI-ASSISTED SOFTWARE?
LABOUR BOUNDS AND ESTIMATION FROM WORK TELEMETRY

Abstract. Software-work telemetry records events whose relationship to human time can change under AI assistance. We determine which labour totals, measured in person-hours, are consistent with observed interval totals or justified bounds on them. Elapsed time to acceptance and output retained at follow-up are reported separately. Each person's available time constrains how much labour could have occurred within a target window. Splitting time at observation endpoints and target-window boundaries gives a finite linear programme with exactly the same possible labour totals, including when observations overlap or tasks share a person's time. When the observations admit an allocation, the minimum and maximum are attainable, as is every total between them. This remains true when each person does one activity at a time, provided activities may start and stop at arbitrary times. Adding separately calculated interval bounds can include totals that no joint allocation permits. When labour is probability-sampled, we correct a prediction total with observed-minus-predicted differences weighted by inverse inclusion probabilities. Predictions are calculated before sampling and kept unchanged across possible samples. Under the stated sampling and measurement assumptions, the corrected estimate averages to true labour over repeated samples. Predictions can increase or reduce its variance. Analytical proofs, Lean-checked interval-integral and schedule-construction lemmas, and exact finite calculations establish these results under their stated assumptions. The proposed measurements still require empirical validation.

1. What the observations determine

Suppose a team records three person-hours of work during a four-hour interval. How much work occurred during its first two hours? If one person did all the work, that person can supply at most two person-hours in either half. The first half must therefore contain between one and two person-hours. Both endpoints are possible: the person could work one hour in the first half and two in the second, or two in the first and one in the second. The interval total thus determines a range of first-half labour totals. Commit times can leave a further ambiguity, since the same event sequence can arise from different amounts of human activity.

Labour is human time allocated to the included work, measured in person-hours. For AI-assisted software work, we count the time spent on all included types of work and report elapsed time to first acceptance and reference output retained at follow-up separately. The accounting includes unsuccessful work and post-acceptance repair. At any time, the fractions of a person's time allocated to different tasks and types of work must sum to at most one. When the observations and each person's available time permit at least one allocation, our linear programme gives the minimum and maximum consistent labour totals. Every total between those endpoints is possible under the same constraints. Establishing a higher minimum or a lower maximum therefore requires additional observations or justified restrictions on how people allocated their time.

When exact labour totals are unavailable, a probability sample of person-intervals (time intervals for individual people) can give an estimate that is unbiased over repeated samples, provided inclusion probabilities are known and positive and allocations are measured accurately. Predictions calculated before sampling supply an initial total. Differences between observed and predicted labour in the sample correct that total, with each difference

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weighted by inverse inclusion probability. The correction improves precision when its sampling variance is lower than that of the labour estimate without predictions. Telemetry can therefore improve a labour estimate even when commit events do not uniquely determine labour. Sampling uncertainty describes how an estimate varies with the selected sample. An identification interval instead contains exactly the labour totals consistent with the specified observations and allocation constraints. Estimating how AI changes labour or output additionally requires a causal study design.

These distinctions matter when telemetry is used to construct a measure of software work. Wright and Ziegler's Standard Coder approach [24] infers coding activity from commit timing and predicts the resulting labels from code-change features. Standard Coding Hours (SCH) can serve as a common reference index, with calibration against independently observed labour required for interpreting it as person-hours. AI may alter both how human activity produces commits and how much work a code change represents. The SPACE framework places activity and efficiency within a broader account of developer productivity [12], while Mozannar et al. examine the interaction time costs of AI-assisted programming [19].

Existing AI studies measure different outcomes in different populations. Peng et al. examine completion time among completers of a programming exercise [20]. Becker et al. study experienced maintainers in familiar repositories, comparing log completion times after adjustment for forecast times [4]. Cui et al. study weekly completed pull requests in organisational experiments [8], using allocation to study groups as an instrument for adoption in their June 2025 manuscript [7, Section 4.1 and Table 3]. The studies differ in their populations, AI tools, working practices and measured outcomes. Their estimates therefore answer different questions. METR's subsequent account of selection and concurrent-agent measurement difficulties further motivates separate labour and elapsed-time records [5]. The calculations here use no data from these studies.

Sections 2 and 3 explain why commits alone need not determine person-hours and define labour, acceptance time and retained output. Section 4 derives the minimum and maximum possible labour totals, and Section 5 uses sampled labour to correct fixed telemetry predictions. Section 6 sets out how to validate these measurements before comparing AI tools and working practices. The proofs apply standard optimisation and sampling results to the stated constraints on allocating people's time. Appendix A gives a shortest-path solution for one person's work of one type on one task.

2. Why event telemetry alone need not identify labour

To examine what commits reveal about human activity, let a minute-indexed hidden variable $Z_t \in \{0,1\}$ indicate an activity state, and let $C_t \in \{0,1\}$ record a commit event. A fitted event model specifies how activity changes from minute to minute and how commits depend on that activity. Interpreting $Z_t = 1$ as "coding" requires validation against independently measured labour. Within the model, different activity distributions can produce the same commit distribution, as the following construction shows.

Proposition 2.1 (Failure of unrestricted identification)**.** *Suppose the states Z_t are independent Bernoulli variables with parameter $\pi \in (0,1)$, and, independently across minutes and of the states, B_t are Bernoulli variables with parameter $c \in (0,1)$. Define $C_t = Z_t B_t$. The joint distribution of all commit observations depends on (π, c) only through πc. In particular, $(\pi, c) = (1/2, 1/5)$ and $(1/4, 2/5)$ give identical commit distributions but different expected active times.*

Proof. Each C_t is Bernoulli with parameter $\theta = \pi c$, and the C_t are independent. For every $n \geq 1$ and every binary string $(e_1, \ldots, e_n)$,

$$\mathbb{P}(C_1 = e_1, \ldots, C_n = e_n) = \theta^{\sum_t e_t}(1-\theta)^{n-\sum_t e_t}. \tag{1}$$

Both parameter pairs give $\theta = 1/10$. In contrast,

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=1}^{n} Z_t\right] = n\pi, \tag{2}$$

which is $n/2$ minutes in the first model and $n/4$ in the second. Thus identical commit distributions can correspond to different expected numbers of active minutes. □

This construction belongs to the independent-state subfamily of a two-state hidden Markov model: the next activity state has the same distribution for either current state. It establishes an ambiguity in the unrestricted model family. Generic-identifiability results for finite-state hidden Markov models concern parameters outside exceptional sets and permit hidden-state relabelling [2, Section 6.1]. Identifying the parameters therefore requires an explicit account of the restrictions or observations that distinguish the candidate models. Restrictions on the activity model, informative code-change features or independent activity observations may supply that distinction.

The interpretation of identified parameters as human labour still requires validation against independently measured person-hours, even when models agree. Under AI assistance, commits can continue while human attention is elsewhere, so the mechanism that produces commits may itself change. Measured interval totals constrain how much labour occurred during a specified period. To use those measurements, we first define which work belongs to each task and the periods over which it is counted.

3. Task accounting with explicit boundaries

3.1. **Defining tasks and allocating human time.** Identify each task by the requirement it addresses, so changes to commits and pull requests preserve the unit being counted. Begin tracking task i at time s_i, when its requested behaviour, conditions for inclusion in the study and acceptance criteria are recorded. Before observing outcomes, define how task splits, mergers and scope changes will be recorded and analysed. Retain the history of changes to requirements and acceptance criteria so the analysis can account for changes in what completion requires.

A split task can retain its identifier while separate records describe its components. Specify whether accepted components count separately or through the completed parent, with each contribution counted once. This choice affects when output is recognised. Suppose one component is accepted before a deadline and another afterwards. Counting the components recognises the first by the deadline, while counting their parent waits for both. Regrouping can therefore change counted output even when the component reference scores, defined in the next subsection, add to the parent's score.

The comparison must also define each group's AI access. Record the available tools and model versions and the tasks on which they may be used. Specify permitted autonomous actions alongside the reviewers and release requirements governing the resulting work. Actual use needs its own record alongside specified access and working practices: difficult tasks may prompt more tool use, while people may decline an available tool. Comparing groups by use alone can therefore mix the effect of access with differences in task difficulty.

The next accounting question is how much human time each task receives. Let $a_{ijr}(t)$ be the fraction of person j's time spent on task i doing work of type r, such as implementation or review, at calendar time t. Each person's allocations across tasks and types of work sum to at most one. Integrating these fractions over time and summing across people and types of work gives cumulative task labour. With finite sets of tasks, people and types of work, and measurable allocation functions, labour through task age $u \geq 0$, measured from the start of tracking, is

$$a_{ijr}(t) \geq 0, \qquad \sum_{i,r} a_{ijr}(t) \leq 1, \qquad H_i(u) = \sum_{j,r} \int_{s_i}^{s_i+u} a_{ijr}(t)\, dt. \tag{3}$$

With time in hours, $H_i(u)$ has units of person-hours. Summing across people allows pair work to contribute two person-hours in one elapsed hour. The allocation constraint limits each person's combined contribution during that hour, including when several sessions run concurrently. The labour total includes all work on the task, from specification and implementation through review, testing and repair. Prompting and integration also consume person-hours. State whether attended waiting belongs in this total, and record unattended tool execution as computing-resource use.

Shared review and platform work require a rule for attributing person-hours to the tasks in Equation (3). Work that the observations leave unattributed needs a separate record. Agent running time belongs in a computing-resource account, with an explicit definition of an agent instance and the resource categories being counted. Report it alongside token use and charges, keeping their units separate from person-hours. Combining these quantities requires an explicit economic conversion and changes the question from labour to cost.

Elapsed time answers a further question: how long does the task take to reach acceptance? Let T_i be elapsed time from the start of tracking to first acceptance. Starting this clock at s_i includes queueing and any reasoning and specification between s_i and the first commit. If the task is permanently abandoned before acceptance, put $T_i = \infty$. This records abandonment as an outcome, while loss of observation is censoring. Acceptance and deployment may occur at different times and then require separate records.

3.2. **Scoring tasks and checking retained output.** Comparing output requires a common reference for what each task delivers. Assign each task a nonnegative reference score S_i^0, recording the scoring-rule version and the task information it uses. The score may count tasks or functional units, or use SCH weights. Retained output has the same unit as this score, and productivity is retained output per person-hour. The superscript 0 denotes the common reference: retain each task's score and use the same scoring rule and weights across comparison groups.

The choice of scoring input determines whether that reference depends on the AI tool being compared. For a causal comparison of fixed task requirements, prefer the requirements recorded when tracking begins. AI can change the final code, so a retrospective code score depends on the resulting implementation. Such a score can still be reported with this dependence made explicit. A nonlinear scoring rule also allows splitting or squashing a change to alter its score. To keep the reference consistent, score the same recorded task information once, or use a requirement-scoring rule whose component scores add to its total. Count the delivered requirement once across failed attempts, retries and reverts.

A score expressed in person-hours needs calibration against independently measured labour. That calibration must identify whose labour is included and the types of work counted, together with the quality requirements and the event at which labour recording ends. Training a predictor on imputed activity states teaches it to predict those states. Interpreting its predictions as person-hours requires independent validation against labour measured on the specified basis.

The reference score describes the task, while follow-up establishes how much accepted output remains. Choose an acceptance deadline at task age $\tau > 0$ and a follow-up duration $\Delta \geq 0$ beginning at first acceptance. Specify the criteria for judging what fraction of an accepted requirement remains satisfied. For accepted tasks, let $R_i(\Delta) \in [0, 1]$ be that fraction at time $s_i + T_i + \Delta$, judged using these criteria. Retained reference output is

$$Q_i(\tau, \Delta) = \begin{cases} S_i^0 R_i(\Delta), & T_i \leq \tau, \\ 0, & T_i > \tau. \end{cases} \tag{4}$$

Applying this definition requires a rule for calculating the retained fraction and distinguishing intentional replacement from defect-driven loss. Surviving lines, successful tests and absence of recorded incidents each provide incomplete observations of particular aspects of quality.

The follow-up procedure must document which defects its checks can detect and measure agreement between reviewers.

The labour and output accounts now give a productivity ratio. For a specified finite set of tasks with positive total labour, define

$$P_H(\tau, \Delta) = \frac{\sum_i Q_i(\tau, \Delta)}{\sum_i H_i(\tau + \Delta)}. \tag{5}$$

The denominator uses a common task-age endpoint, summing labour through $\tau + \Delta$ for every task in that set. It includes labour on rejected, unfinished and abandoned tasks, together with attributable work after acceptance. Early acceptance leaves more time for repair within this labour window than late acceptance. Ending repair accounting exactly Δ after each acceptance would therefore define a different denominator. Measuring the ratio defined here requires recording that endpoint and following every task for $\tau + \Delta$.

Tasks with zero human labour can contribute retained output. The productivity ratio is defined only when the tasks' total labour is positive. Report retained output and total person-hours separately.

3.3. **The observations and the three clocks.** Acceptance is judged against the deadline τ. Retained output is checked at task age $T_i + \Delta$, using actual acceptance as the start of follow-up. Labour is counted through task age $\tau + \Delta$ for every task, whether or not it has been accepted. A complete task history must therefore supply observations through these different endpoints, including the retained output and repair work following acceptance.

Even a complete history may permit several labour allocations. A record *point-identifies* realised labour when at least one time allocation is consistent with the recorded observations and model constraints, and every such allocation gives the same total. Proposition 2.1 instead asks whether the probability distribution of observed events uniquely determines a population parameter. The next section derives the smallest and largest labour totals consistent with interval observations.

4. Attainable labour ranges from interval observations

An interval total can leave open when people worked within it. We seek the labour totals possible within the target windows under all observations and the allocation constraint in (3). The *identified range* contains exactly the totals obtainable by allocations satisfying these conditions. This definition follows the general partial-identification perspective [23, Section 1]. We begin with one person's work in one interval, then account jointly for overlapping observations and shared time.

4.1. **Using the person's capacity.** One person can contribute at most one person-hour in an elapsed hour. Knowing who supplied an interval total therefore limits how much of that labour could have occurred before or after a specified time. A total across several people must be compared with their combined available time.

Proposition 4.1 (Attainable contribution from one interval)**.** *Let $\ell < u$, $c \in [\ell, u]$ and $v \in [0, u - \ell]$. Among measurable allocations $a : [\ell, u] \to [0, 1]$ with $\int_\ell^u a(t)\,dt = v$, the attainable values of $x = \int_\ell^c a(t)\,dt$ are exactly*

$$[\max\{0, v - (u - c)\},\ \min\{v, c - \ell\}]\,. \tag{6}$$

If $v < 0$ or $v > u - \ell$, no such allocation exists.

Proof. Nonnegativity and capacity on the two pieces imply

$$0 \le x \le c - \ell, \qquad 0 \le v - x \le u - c.$$

Together, these inequalities give (6). Conversely, for any x in this interval, set $a = x/(c - \ell)$ before c and $a = (v - x)/(u - c)$ after c. Each value lies in $[0, 1]$ and gives the required

integral. Omit a zero-length piece when c is an endpoint: the corresponding numerator is then zero. Finally, integrating $0 \le a \le 1$ gives the necessary condition $0 \le v \le u - \ell$. □

For one person, 3/2 person-hours in a two-hour interval imply between 1/2 and 1 person-hours in its first hour. Capacity narrows the range permitted by nonnegativity alone, $[0, 3/2]$, while leaving the first-hour total and timing partly open. If $v = u - \ell$, the total uses all the person's available time, so the labour before any time within it equals the elapsed time from its start. The argument extends to an interior subinterval $[b, c] \subseteq [\ell, u]$: applying the construction to that subinterval and the time outside it gives every possible labour total in the subinterval, $[\max\{0, v - ((u - \ell) - (c - b))\}, \min\{v, c - b\}]$.

Combining contributions requires checking whether their separate extrema can occur together. Separately calculated bounds can be added when each contribution is counted once. Attaining the summed lower bound requires every component minimum together, and attaining the summed upper bound requires every component maximum together. Disjoint intervals of one person, or intervals belonging to distinct people, can be combined when no other constraints link them. Overlapping observations or several tasks competing for the same person's time require a joint calculation.

For example, suppose one person spends one person-hour on each of two tasks during $[0, 2]$. Each task separately allows $[0, 1]$ person-hours before time 1. Together, the tasks use all the person's available time on $[0, 2]$, so exactly one person-hour must fall before time 1. Adding the separately calculated bounds would instead give $[0, 2]$. Figure 1 shows how the shared capacity restricts the jointly feasible first-hour totals within the separately permitted ranges. Panel (c) gives one schedule for the marked midpoint, illustrating the one-activity-at-a-time reconstruction proved below.

4.2. **Replacing allocation histories with interval totals.** For the joint calculation, call one person's work of one type on one task a stream. Fix finite sets of tasks $\mathcal{I}$, people $\mathcal{J}$ and types of work $\mathcal{R}$, a set of tasks to be studied $\mathcal{C} \subseteq \mathcal{I}$, and a bounded calendar-time domain $[b_0, b_K]$ with $b_0 < b_K$ containing every observation interval and target window. An admissible history consists of measurable $a_{ijr} \ge 0$ satisfying $\sum_{i,r} a_{ijr}(t) \le 1$ almost everywhere for every person j.

The list of people and the rules for attributing time to tasks determine whose labour and which work enter this calculation. Whether the records cover the intended work requires measurement evidence. Work outside $\mathcal{C}$ can be recorded separately when it uses the same people's time without contributing to the labour total for $\mathcal{C}$.

For observations $\nu = 1, \dots, M$, specify an interval $[\ell_\nu, u_\nu]$ within this domain, a set $G_\nu \subseteq \mathcal{I} \times \mathcal{J} \times \mathcal{R}$ of streams whose labour the observation includes, and finite labour bounds $v_\nu^- \le v_\nu^+$, in person-hours. These bounds impose

$$v_\nu^- \le \sum_{(i,j,r) \in G_\nu} \int_{\ell_\nu}^{u_\nu} a_{ijr}(t)\, dt \le v_\nu^+. \tag{7}$$

Exact interval totals use $v_\nu^- = v_\nu^+$. Justified limits on rounding or measurement error may instead give different lower and upper bounds. A Horvitz–Thompson estimate varies with the selected sample. Its sampling uncertainty must be accounted for before the estimate can justify either inequality.

Form the sorted distinct endpoints $b_0 < \cdots < b_K$ from the domain boundaries, every observation endpoint and every target boundary, and call the intervals between successive endpoints cells. For the denominator in (5), target boundaries include the start of tracking s_i and the end of the labour observation window $c_i = s_i + \tau + \Delta$ for every task in $\mathcal{C}$. Translating time since tracking began into calendar time before partitioning ensures that simultaneous work by the same person shares one capacity constraint. Cells outside a target window must remain whenever an observation spans them, because some of the observed labour may have occurred outside the window. Put $d_k = b_k - b_{k-1} > 0$ and let x_{ijrk} denote the labour

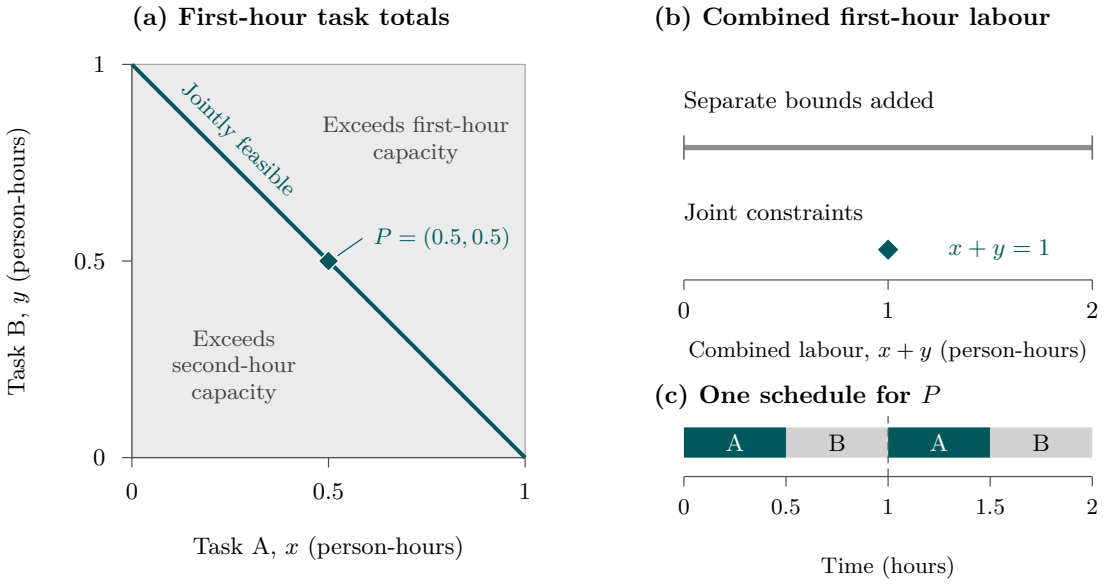


FIGURE 1. **Shared capacity determines the combined first-hour labour.** Constructed example: one person spends one person-hour on each of two tasks during two hours. In (a), x and y are the tasks' first-hour labour totals. The shaded square satisfies the separate bounds; only the diagonal satisfies the person's capacity in both hours. In (b), adding the separate bounds permits between zero and two person-hours, whereas the joint constraints require exactly one. In (c), one full-attention schedule attains the marked point $P = (0.5, 0.5)$: each task receives half an hour in each hour, with one activity at a time. The example allows the person to switch tasks at arbitrary times; the schedule is neither unique nor observed.

allocated to stream (i, j, r) in cell k. These cell totals preserve exactly the possible target values, as follows.

Proposition 4.2 (Exact cell reduction and attainable labour range)**.** *Under the preceding model, define the finite-dimensional feasible set $\mathcal{P}$ by*

$$x_{ijrk} \geq 0, \qquad \sum_{i,r} x_{ijrk} \leq d_k \qquad \text{for every } j, k, \tag{8}$$

$$v_\nu^- \leq \sum_{(i,j,r)\in G_\nu} \sum_{k:\,[b_{k-1},b_k]\subseteq[\ell_\nu,u_\nu]} x_{ijrk} \leq v_\nu^+ \qquad \text{for every } \nu. \tag{9}$$

Fix real weights w_{ijrk} and define the target for a continuous-time allocation history by multiplying each cell integral by w_{ijrk} and summing. The attainable target values over histories satisfying the capacity and observation constraints equal $h(\mathcal{P})$, where $h(x) = \sum_{i,j,r,k} w_{ijrk} x_{ijrk}$. In particular, the denominator in (5) uses $w_{ijrk} = 1$ exactly when $i \in \mathcal{C}$ and $[b_{k-1}, b_k] \subseteq [s_i, c_i]$, and zero otherwise. If $\mathcal{P}$ is nonempty, its target range is the closed interval

$$[H_{\min}, H_{\max}] = \left[\min_{x\in\mathcal{P}} h(x),\ \max_{x\in\mathcal{P}} h(x)\right]. \tag{10}$$

Both endpoints and every value between them are attained, even if every $a_{ijr}(t)$ is restricted to $\{0, 1\}$, so that each person does at most one type of work on one task at a time. If $\mathcal{P}$ is empty, the observations and capacity assumptions are inconsistent.

Proof. Integrating any such history over each cell gives nonnegative cell labour totals. Integrating each person's allocation limit gives (8). Splitting each observation at the cell

boundaries gives (9). The weighted target total is unchanged because its weights are constant on cells.

Conversely, fix $x \in \mathcal{P}$. For each person and cell, order the task–type-of-work pairs and divide the cell into consecutive blocks whose lengths are their respective x_{ijrk}. The capacity constraint ensures that these blocks fit inside the cell. Use half-open blocks to avoid overlap at their boundaries. During each block, set the corresponding allocation to one and all others to zero. Leave any remaining time idle. Omit zero-length blocks and give the final domain endpoint the same allocation values as the last block. These measurable allocations reproduce every cell labour total, so all observation bounds remain satisfied and the target value is unchanged. Each person works on at most one task and type of work at a time, with finitely many changes. Thus even these restricted allocation functions give exactly the same possible target values as the finite feasible set.

The constraints define a closed convex set. Each coordinate is between zero and d_k, so a nonempty $\mathcal{P}$ is compact and a linear functional attains its extrema. Convex combinations of minimising and maximising cell vectors attain every intermediate value. Reconstructing each such vector by consecutive blocks supplies an allocation with values in $\{0, 1\}$ for each intermediate total. □

This reduction makes the extreme target totals computable by linear programmes, each with $|\mathcal{I}||\mathcal{J}||\mathcal{R}|K$ variables, $|\mathcal{J}|K$ shared-capacity constraints and $2M$ observation inequalities, in addition to nonnegativity. A known period of unavailability can be included by adding its boundaries to the partition and setting that person's cell labour totals to zero within it.

The reconstruction realises fractional cell totals with one activity at a time. It uses at most $|\mathcal{I}||\mathcal{R}| + 1$ constant blocks per person in each cell, including idle time. The reconstruction requires work to be allowed to start, stop and change type or task at arbitrary times within a cell. Minimum session lengths, restrictions on interruption, smoothness constraints and switching costs require a separate analysis.

Preserving the integrals while replacing fractional allocations by one activity at a time is a finite-partition instance of the Dvoretzky–Wald–Wolfowitz purification theorem [11, Theorem 4]. See also [17, Section 2]. The consecutive-block construction gives the required history directly and bounds its number of blocks.

4.3. **Checking the bounds and allowing observation error.** To check an endpoint, pair an attaining allocation with an inequality ruling out more extreme totals. Collect the cell totals and target weights into vectors x and w, and write the capacity and observation inequalities as $Ax \le b$, with $x \ge 0$ kept separate. A lower observation bound is included by reversing its sign. Nonnegative multipliers λ and μ satisfying

$$A^{\mathsf{T}}\lambda \ge w, \qquad A^{\mathsf{T}}\mu \ge -w \quad \Longrightarrow \quad -\mu^{\mathsf{T}}b \le h(x) \le \lambda^{\mathsf{T}}b \qquad (x \in \mathcal{P}) \tag{11}$$

give bounds by weighted sums of the original inequalities: $w^{\mathsf{T}}x \le \lambda^{\mathsf{T}}Ax \le \lambda^{\mathsf{T}}b$, and likewise for $-w$. For a nonempty $\mathcal{P}$, linear-programming strong duality ensures that suitable multipliers give exactly $H_{\min}$ and $H_{\max}$ [6, Sections 5.2–5.3]. An allocation attaining an endpoint and multipliers giving the same bound together certify that endpoint. Rational certificates can be checked by exact arithmetic without repeating the optimisation. A numerical solver's success flag alone does not supply this check.

The same multipliers also bound totals after observation limits widen. Increasing an upper observation bound or decreasing a lower one increases the corresponding entry of b. If these changes give $b + \varepsilon$, with $\varepsilon \ge 0$ and zero entries for unchanged constraints, the same multipliers bound every newly permitted target total by

$$[-\mu^{\mathsf{T}}(b + \varepsilon),\ \lambda^{\mathsf{T}}(b + \varepsilon)]. \tag{12}$$

The same weighted sums of inequalities give these bounds, as in the sensitivity analysis of [6, Section 5.6]. Reoptimising may give a smaller interval. The observation process must still justify the error limits.

Sampled observation limits require a coverage argument. Suppose random lower and upper bounds contain all true observation totals simultaneously with probability at least $1-\alpha$, where $0<\alpha<1$. If the true history satisfies the allocation constraints, its cell vector belongs to the resulting random feasible set on that event. Optimising then gives an interval containing the true target total with probability at least $1-\alpha$. An empty feasible set counts as a failure to cover.

The simultaneous-coverage condition requires an argument for the actual sampling and measurement process. Coverage of $1-\alpha$ for each observation separately does not establish the same probability of covering them all. By the union bound, marginal error probabilities whose sum is at most α suffice. The resulting interval has a sampling-coverage guarantee, rather than the exact-data interpretation of (10).

A separate development in Lean 4, using mathlib [9, 22], checks that interval integrals equal sums of cell totals and that integrating each person's allocation limit gives the cell-capacity constraint. It constructs schedules in which each person does at most one activity at a time, preserving the observation totals and weighted targets. It also checks the bounds from supplied allocations and dual multipliers, and the implication from simultaneous coverage of observation totals to coverage of the target total. The existence of minimising and maximising allocations and dual multipliers, and the stated bound on the number of blocks, remain outside this formal supplement. The Rust solver is tested separately. The supplement does not prove that the Rust solver's source code implements the Lean definitions.

4.4. **From labour bounds to productivity.** For the denominator in (5), let $Q=\sum_{i\in\mathcal{C}} Q_i(\tau,\Delta)$ be retained output known exactly. With $Q\geq 0$ and $H_{\min}>0$, dividing this output by the largest and smallest possible labour totals gives the identified productivity interval $[Q/H_{\max}, Q/H_{\min}]$.

Quality bounds introduce a further joint-feasibility requirement. Justified quality bounds $0\leq Q_-\leq Q\leq Q_+$ give an interval $[Q_-/H_{\max}, Q_+/H_{\min}]$ containing every feasible output-to-labour ratio. It is the exact range only when every ratio in it can be produced by an output total and labour total that are jointly permitted. It is sufficient for every pair in $[Q_-,Q_+]\times[H_{\min},H_{\max}]$ to be permitted. A lower labour bound of zero cannot be used as a divisor. The acceptance times and the recorded fractions of requirements still met in (4) remain fixed throughout the allocation optimisation.

5. Estimating labour from sampled allocations

The preceding bounds describe every labour total permitted by given interval observations. Sampling raises a different question: how can selected person-intervals support an estimate of total labour? The estimate varies with the selected intervals, so entering it as an exact observation can exclude the true allocation through sampling error. We therefore develop its sampling properties separately. The difference estimator below uses sampled labour to correct a telemetry prediction total. Under its sampling and measurement assumptions, the corrected estimate averages to the true labour total over repeated samples.

The sampling frame determines which work the estimate can represent. This complete list of person-intervals must cover all target work, including off-keyboard reasoning, review and coordination. Short diaries and task records can show how much of each selected interval a person spent on that work. Their accuracy requires an independent check of a subsample, with identified reviewers and evidence for resolving discrepancies. Report disagreement and investigate its causes. Nonresponse and inaccurate recall concern the records within the frame, while omitted work concerns the frame's coverage. Each requires its own investigation.

5.1. **Predictions calculated before sampling.** Predictions for every person-interval supply an initial labour total. A probability sample estimates the difference between that total and true labour. In each sampled interval, observed labour minus predicted labour is the residual. Dividing each residual by its inclusion probability and summing gives a correction

that, under the conditions below, averages over repeated samples to the true total minus the prediction total. Denis and Haddou give this fixed-prediction estimator and its variance under the sampling design explicitly [10, Section 2.3, equations (2)–(4)]. Prediction-powered inference also identifies its estimator of a mean as a difference estimator and considers finite-population extensions [3, Section 1.4 and Appendix B of the accompanying preprint].

Partition each person's target observation period into non-overlapping intervals. Let $U = \{1, \dots, M\}$, $M \geq 1$, be the complete, fixed frame of these person-intervals. For interval m, let $d_m > 0$ be its length in hours and $a_m \in [0, 1]$ its average allocation to the target work. Its labour is $y_m = d_m a_m$ person-hours, and the population total is $H = \sum_U y_m$.

For every frame unit, retain a prediction f_m in person-hours. A raw SCH value requires a stated conversion to labour units before it can serve as f_m. Each unit's prediction must also remain the same whichever sample is drawn. Training on an independent earlier population can satisfy this condition by holding all predictions fixed before sampling allocations to correct the predicted total.

Proposition 5.1 (Fixed-prediction difference estimator)**.** *For a probability sample $s \subseteq U$ with known first-order inclusion probabilities $\pi_m > 0$, set $r_m = y_m - f_m$ and*

$$\widehat{H}_{\text{diff}} = \sum_{m \in U} f_m + \sum_{m \in s} \frac{y_m - f_m}{\pi_m}. \tag{13}$$

If y_m and f_m are fixed under the design and every sampled labour value is observed accurately, then $\mathbb{E}_s[\widehat{H}_{\text{diff}}] = H$, where $\mathbb{E}_s$ averages over the sampling design.

Proof. Write $I_m = \mathbf{1}\{m \in s\}$. Linearity and $\mathbb{E}_s[I_m] = \pi_m$ give

$$\mathbb{E}_s[\widehat{H}_{\text{diff}}] = \sum_U f_m + \sum_U \frac{\mathbb{E}_s[I_m]}{\pi_m}(y_m - f_m) = \sum_U y_m.$$

□

The correction therefore preserves design-unbiasedness even when the fixed prediction total differs from H. Taking $f_m = 0$ gives the Horvitz–Thompson (HT) estimator [13],

$$\widehat{H}_{\text{HT}} = \sum_{m \in s} \frac{d_m a_m}{\pi_m}. \tag{14}$$

The records must distinguish observed zeros from missing observations. For every frame interval, record whether it was selected with an observed allocation, including zero, selected with no recorded allocation value (nonresponse), or unselected. The proof concerns true allocation values, so unbiasedness in the presence of measurement error requires additional assumptions on that error.

5.2. **Precision depends on residuals and the sampling design.** The residuals and sampling design jointly determine precision. Let $\pi_{mk} = \mathbb{E}_s[I_m I_k]$ be the probability that both frame units are selected, including $\pi_{mm} = \pi_m$. The exact variance over repeated samples is

$$\text{Var}_s(\widehat{H}_{\text{diff}}) = \sum_{m,k \in U} \frac{\pi_{mk} - \pi_m \pi_k}{\pi_m \pi_k} r_m r_k. \tag{15}$$

Expanding the variance of $\sum_U I_m r_m / \pi_m$ gives this expression: how often pairs of units are selected together determines their inclusion covariances. Calculating the variance from (15) would also require residuals for unsampled units, which are generally unknown. Estimating it therefore requires the actual sampling design and satisfaction of the chosen variance estimator's conditions on joint inclusion probabilities.

For simple random sampling without replacement from $M \geq 2$ units, let the fixed sample size satisfy $1 \leq n \leq M$. Every size-n subset has the same probability and $\pi_m = n/M$. Write

$$S_r^2 = \frac{1}{M-1}\sum_U (r_m - \bar{r}_U)^2, \qquad S_y^2 = \frac{1}{M-1}\sum_U (y_m - \bar{y}_U)^2.$$

The inclusion covariances in (15) give

$$\mathrm{Var}_s(\widehat{H}_{\mathrm{diff}}) = \frac{M^2}{n}\left(1 - \frac{n}{M}\right) S_r^2, \qquad \mathrm{Var}_s(\widehat{H}_{\mathrm{HT}}) = \frac{M^2}{n}\left(1 - \frac{n}{M}\right) S_y^2. \tag{16}$$

For $2 \leq n \leq M$, an unbiased estimator of the design variance is

$$\widehat{V}_{\mathrm{diff}} = \frac{M^2}{n}\left(1 - \frac{n}{M}\right) s_r^2, \qquad s_r^2 = \frac{1}{n-1}\sum_{m \in s} (r_m - \bar{r}_s)^2. \tag{17}$$

Indeed, $s_r^2 = [n(n-1)]^{-1}\sum_{m<k,\, m,k\in s}(r_m - r_k)^2$. Each pair has inclusion probability $n(n-1)/[M(M-1)]$, so $\mathbb{E}_s[s_r^2] = S_r^2$. A one-unit sample from a larger population cannot supply this variance estimate. Measuring every unit gives zero sampling variance, including in a single-unit population. Measurement error remains a separate question.

For $n < M$, the difference estimator has lower sampling variance than HT exactly when $S_r^2 < S_y^2$: the residuals must have lower population variance than the person-interval labour totals. For example, consider $M = 4$, $n = 2$, and $y = (0, 2, 4, 6)$. The true total is 12, and HT variance is $80/3$. Using $f = (1, 3, 3, 5)$ for every sample yields variance $16/3$, while using $f = (6, 4, 2, 0)$ yields $320/3$. The second predictor gives four times the HT variance, although the difference estimator remains design-unbiased with either predictor.

Enumerating all six samples reproduces these variances and confirms that each estimator averages to the true total. It also verifies that (17) averages to each corresponding variance. These finite checks establish the calculations for the two predictors. A workplace study must determine whether its code-derived predictions give a residual total with lower sampling variance than the labour estimate without predictions.

5.3. **Failure cases and implementation checks.** Fitting predictions to the correction sample can change the estimator's expectation. For $M = 2$, $n = 1$ and $y = (0, 2)$, suppose a fitted rule memorises the selected outcome and predicts zero for the other unit. Its observed residual is always zero, so the correction leaves the fitted total unchanged. The resulting difference estimate is 0 or 2, each with probability $1/2$, giving expectation 1 rather than $H = 2$. A method trained on the sampled units therefore needs a separate unbiasedness argument under the actual finite-population sampling design.

Clipping can also change the estimator's expectation. The estimate can be negative even though true labour is nonnegative. With $y = (0, 0)$, $f = (10, 0)$ and one uniformly selected unit, (13) is -10 or 10 with equal probability. Clipping at zero changes its expectation from 0 to 5. Reporting the signed estimate preserves the stated estimator while leaving an implausible result available for investigation. Dividing retained output by an unbiased labour estimate also need not yield an unbiased productivity estimate.

The accompanying implementation reports estimates with their calculated sign, preserves observed zeros, and records nonresponse separately from unselected units. It rejects inputs with missing required information, selected intervals without allocation measurements, and inconsistent values. For a supplied general sampling design it reports point estimates. For simple random sampling it also reports variance and standard error under the conditions above.

These input checks establish whether supplied records satisfy the implementation's rules. Evidence from collection must establish that the frame covers the work, allocations are measured accurately and units were sampled by the stated method.

Exhaustive finite tests check the examples above, input validation, complete censuses and single-unit populations. A confidence interval requires a separate argument that its stated coverage holds under the sampling design.

6. Validating the measurements

The mathematical results depend on observations that cover the target work and measure its person-hours accurately. A measurement pilot must test these premises before comparing AI tools. Define the included tasks and types of work, how hours are attributed to them and which person-intervals are available for sampling. Record the reference scoring rule and acceptance deadline together with the retained-output criteria before collection. These choices determine what the measurements describe.

The pilot must establish how reliably and at what effort those records can be collected. Record disagreement over allocations and nonresponse, and track follow-up completeness and collection time. Report each by comparison group, type of work and explicitly defined task category. This evidence informs the sampling effort and precision that a later comparison can support.

Validation must also address the particular guarantee being used. Interval bounds require independently checked totals with justified limits on measurement error. For target windows chosen before observing outcomes, compare the sums of separately calculated lower and upper labour bounds with the joint minimum and maximum. This shows whether accounting jointly for each person's available time raises the minimum or lowers the maximum.

For sampled labour, the question is whether fixed predictions improve precision. Compare the variance over repeated samples with and without predictions calculated before sampling and kept unchanged whichever sample is drawn. Retain the inclusion probabilities and joint sampling-design information needed to calculate uncertainty. The following subsection explains how sampling error also affects the assessment of prediction accuracy.

6.1. Comparing predictions with sampled labour.

Comparing a prediction with sampled labour combines prediction error with sampling error. Use labour recorded for teams or periods excluded when fitting the prediction rule, keeping predictions unchanged whichever validation sample is drawn. The following calculations separate prediction error against true labour from sampling variance.

Treat each task's labour H in a finite validation population as fixed. Let f be its prediction, calculated before validation sampling and unchanged whichever sample is drawn, and suppose $\mathbb{E}_s[\widehat{H}] = H$ with finite design variance. Then

$$\mathbb{E}_s[f - \widehat{H}] = f - H,$$
$$\mathbb{E}_s[(f - \widehat{H})^2] = (f - H)^2 + \mathrm{Var}_s(\widehat{H}).$$

Expand the square: the cross term vanishes because $\mathbb{E}_s[\widehat{H} - H] = 0$. These identities hold for each task under its stated sampling design. Aggregate uncertainty additionally depends on covariances between tasks' estimates.

For a second prediction g calculated before the same validation sample and unchanged whichever sample is drawn, subtraction cancels the common sampling variance:

$$\mathbb{E}_s[(f - \widehat{H})^2 - (g - \widehat{H})^2] = (f - H)^2 - (g - H)^2.$$

Over repeated validation samples, the average difference between the two squared prediction errors equals their difference calculated against true labour. Estimating either predictor's squared error against true labour, or quantifying sampling uncertainty in their comparison, requires further sampling-design information. Absolute error requires a separate analysis.

To examine absolute error, consider eight one-hour person-intervals that have allocations $(1, 1, 1, 1, 0, 0, 0, 0)$. Sample one uniformly, with inclusion probability $1/8$. True labour is $H = 4$, whereas its HT estimate is 0 or 8, each with probability $1/2$. A perfect prediction

$f = 4$ consequently has apparent absolute error 4 against the sampled estimate. The interval $[3.5, 4.5]$ always contains true labour but never contains the sampled estimate. The signed difference between prediction and sampled estimate remains unbiased for the prediction's error against true labour. Absolute error and interval coverage calculated against $\widehat{H}$ measure agreement with the sampled estimate, including its sampling error.

To examine accuracy against true labour, record allocations for every person-interval in each target window for a validation subset of tasks. Independently check those records, identifying the reviewers and evidence used to resolve discrepancies. State how checking remains independent of recording, and report remaining measurement error. Alternatively, use a measurement model under which the observations uniquely determine the chosen accuracy measure. Retain inclusion probabilities and joint sampling-design information for uncertainty calculations.

Report systematic overstatement or understatement and the size of individual prediction errors by study group, type of work and explicitly defined task category. Correlation between group averages leaves these questions open.

Output-accounting rules also need validation. Test whether task splitting, code-change squashing or changes to the task information supplied to the scoring rule alter the reference score. Report reviewer disagreement and follow-up completeness alongside prediction error. Recalculate comparisons between study groups using plausible amounts of missing labour and disputed retained-output scores. If plausible measurement errors reverse which group has the better outcome, the choice between AI tools and working practices depends on how that uncertainty is resolved or accepted.

6.2. **Conditions for comparing AI tools and working practices.** Once the measurements are validated, a causal comparison must define which work its conclusion concerns. AI adoption can change which work is requested or undertaken, so comparing a fixed workload and studying an organisation's incoming work answer different questions. For a fixed-workload comparison, set the conditions for including tasks before allocating tasks, people or teams to comparison groups, and keep those conditions unchanged. State how work done before group allocation is counted, and retain records of postponed, rejected and abandoned requests. An organisation-wide adoption comparison needs a common calendar window and records of incoming requests and work in progress. Each design must identify its target population and explain how observations are weighted to represent it.

Group formation must account for work shared between teams. Reviewers, limited computing resources for agents and reusable components can transmit the effects of one team's AI access to another. These links therefore matter both when forming groups and when analysing outcomes. Analyse outcomes by the original group allocation, recording actual tool use separately.

The allocation also determines the level at which causal uncertainty must be calculated. More commits within a team add records while leaving the number of independently allocated teams unchanged. Calculate uncertainty at the level at which teams, people or other units were allocated to groups, and also allow for sampling labour and checking quality in subsets.

Retained-output comparisons require common criteria and a common follow-up procedure across groups. Two reviewers should check a subset independently so their disagreement can be measured. The check can itself trigger repair, making the timing of feedback and any loss of reviewer blinding—reviewers learning which group a task belongs to—part of the measurement record. Count resulting repair within the stated labour window. Extending retained-output estimates from a checked subset to all tasks requires known selection probabilities and assumptions addressing any effect of the check on subsequent work. Report severe defects separately because a retained fraction cannot describe every security or reliability consequence.

Interpreting an apparent labour saving requires the corresponding acceptance and retained-output records. Complete follow-up through $\tau + \Delta$ as required by Section 3, distinguishing

permanent abandonment from loss of observation. Incomplete follow-up requires explicit assumptions or bounds for missing outcomes. Report labour, acceptance and retained output together, since reduced labour may accompany more abandonment. Present retained output and positive total labour alongside their productivity ratio, accounting for uncertainty in both quantities and their dependence.

The decision criterion must then specify how much improvement is useful and how much quality loss is acceptable. Prespecify the improvement thresholds and the maximum acceptable reduction in quality (the noninferiority margin). Establishing that a loss lies within this margin requires evidence about its magnitude and uncertainty. Failure to detect a reduction alone leaves that requirement unresolved. The following experiment makes these criteria explicit for a fixed-workload comparison.

6.3. **A specified causal experiment.** A fixed-workload experiment would compare teams given a recorded AI toolset and working practices with teams using the same ordinary development and review process without generative AI. Record each team's task requirements, acceptance criteria and reference scores before choosing groups. Pair teams using repository domain, previous workload and experience, then use an independent fair coin within each pair to choose which team receives AI access [15]. The groups remain parallel throughout, and the primary analysis follows allocation, with actual tool use recorded separately.

Shared reviewers, developers, computing capacity or code can transmit effects between teams [14]. If these links require groups containing several teams, revise the estimator weights and planning before randomisation to preserve the equal-team target.

Normalise both outcomes by the initial workload: for each team, divide total labour through task age $\tau + \Delta$ by its initial reference-score total, and divide retained output by that same fixed total. Failed and abandoned tasks remain in the labour total and contribute no retained output when they miss the acceptance deadline. The two primary causal quantities are the equal-team mean differences in these outcomes, estimated by averaging the AI-minus-comparator differences within team pairs. A benefit claim requires both a worthwhile labour reduction and a retained-output loss smaller than a stated maximum. Failure to detect a quality reduction does not meet that requirement [21].

The provisional criteria require a saving exceeding one person-hour per reference unit and a retained-output loss below five percentage points. For uncertainty and measurement bias, the protocol uses approximate one-sided 97.5% Student-t bounds from independent pair differences, expanded by 0.2 person-hours per reference unit for labour and 0.01 for the retained fraction. Both expanded bounds must meet their respective criteria. These measurement-bias allowances require empirical justification, and the practical thresholds require substantive agreement before a principal study. Any unresolved team endpoint prevents a benefit claim under this plan.

The accompanying protocol specifies a separate six-pair measurement pilot and provisional $\tau = \Delta = 336$-hour clocks (14 calendar days each). Twenty thousand simulated experiments per design and scenario compare 48 and 96 teams under hypothetical outcome distributions, measurement bias and missing endpoints, including cases at each benefit boundary [18]. Neither team count reaches the required 90% probability of meeting both criteria across the required useful-effect scenarios. Before choosing a principal sample size, the pilot must establish defensible ranges for measurement error, variability and endpoint completeness. Its observed treatment effect must not determine that choice [1]. The experiment remains specified and unrun. These hypothetical planning calculations report no causal workplace result.

7. Scope and next observations

Different distributions of human activity can produce identical commit distributions. Interval totals or justified bounds, together with each person's available time, restrict how

much work could have occurred during a specified period. Splitting time at every observation endpoint and target-window boundary gives a finite optimisation problem with exactly the same possible labour totals. Adding separately calculated interval bounds can include totals that would require someone to work beyond their available time. The summed lower and upper bounds are exact only if work allocations achieving the respective component bounds can occur together.

Probability sampling permits design-unbiased estimation when the frame covers the target work, inclusion probabilities are known and positive, and sampled allocations are measured accurately. A fixed telemetry predictor improves precision only when estimating its total residual has lower sampling variance than estimating labour without predictions. Diaries and task records can supply the observations. Whether they capture reasoning and coordination and accurately record how people divide their time requires empirical evidence. The unbiasedness and precision results depend on the stated measurement and sampling assumptions. Establishing a causal benefit from AI adoption requires a further comparison of AI tools and working practices.

The next empirical step is the measurement pilot specified in Section 6.3. It must test whether task records capture person-hours across the included types of work and support independent checks of retained output through follow-up. Disagreement, missing records and collection effort will inform the measurement procedure and size of the proposed fixed-workload experiment. A study of organisation-wide adoption would address a different question because AI can also change incoming requirements. The mathematical results establish which labour totals the observations permit, when sampling gives an unbiased estimate and when predictions calculated before sampling reduce its variance.

Appendix A. A shortest-path solution for one allocation stream

For one person's work of one type on one task, let $0 \le a \le 1$ be the allocation function. Represent the observations of Section 4 by cumulative labour at their endpoints. Using the sorted endpoints and cell lengths defined there, set $z_k = \int_{b_0}^{b_k} a(t)\,dt$. Labour between endpoints is the difference between these totals. Represent an inequality $z_q - z_p \le w$ by a directed edge $p \to q$ of weight w.

The graph combines capacity limits with the observed interval totals. Adjacent endpoints receive edges $k-1 \to k$ of weight d_k and $k \to k-1$ of weight zero, encoding the maximum available time and nonnegativity. Observation bounds on $[b_p, b_q]$ add edges $p \to q$ of weight v^+ and $q \to p$ of weight $-v^-$. An exact observed labour total v therefore gives edge weights v and $-v$. This is the standard difference-constraints representation [16, Slides 6–11]. Path weights then bound differences in cumulative labour.

Proposition A.1 (Attainable cumulative bounds from graph distances)**.** *The observations for this single allocation function admit an allocation if and only if this graph has no directed cycle of negative total weight. When such an allocation exists, let $D(p,q)$ be the shortest-path weight from p to q. For any endpoint pair $p \le q$, the identified range of $\int_{b_p}^{b_q} a(t)\,dt$ is*

$$[-D(q,p),\ D(p,q)]. \tag{18}$$

Proof. Summing edge inequalities around a cycle gives 0 at the left, so a negative cycle is inconsistent. Conversely, adjacent edges make every vertex reachable from every other. In the absence of negative cycles, all shortest-path weights are finite and $D(r,r) = 0$. For any starting vertex r, the values $z_k = D(r,k)$ satisfy each edge inequality because $D(r,v) \le D(r,u) + w$ for an edge $u \to v$ of weight w. Subtracting z_0 makes initial cumulative labour zero without changing differences. The inequalities for adjacent endpoints give cell labour totals in $[0, d_k]$. Allocations constant within each cell can produce these totals and satisfy the observations.

Summing inequalities along paths yields $z_q - z_p \le D(p,q)$ and $z_q - z_p \ge -D(q,p)$. Using p as the starting vertex gives an allocation achieving the upper bound. Using q gives an

allocation achieving the lower bound. Convex combinations of these allocations give every labour total between those bounds. □

The reference checker implements these bounds with exact rational arithmetic and an all-pairs shortest-path calculation. Given indexed, sorted endpoints, graph construction and this calculation use $O((K+1)^3 + M)$ arithmetic operations and $O((K+1)^2 + M)$ storage. Bit costs depend on the encoded rational inputs. The checker compares the bounds and the allocations attaining them against an independent enumeration of finite allocations, including overlapping interval observations and inconsistent inputs. These constructed examples check the calculation against the proved result, while empirical measurements are still needed to validate the observation process. Several task streams sharing a person's capacity require the joint formulation in Proposition 4.2, because the scalar graph represents only one allocation.

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